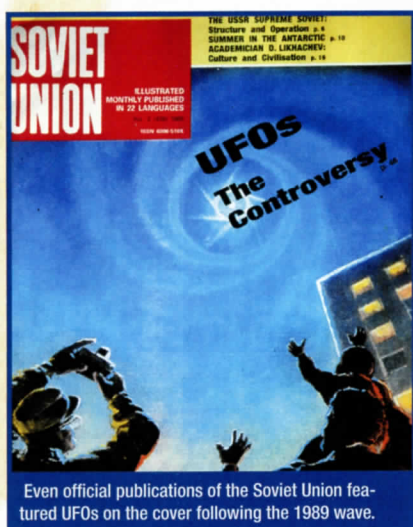


**B**y the fall of 1989, the economic, political, and social reforms known as *glasnost* and *perestroika* implemented by the last Communist premier of the Soviet Union, Mikhail Gorbachev, were changing the once monolithic and totalitarian society of the USSR. *Glasnost* had unshackled the Soviet media, which was now relatively free to cover a wide range of once-banned subjects including UFOs. Russian journalists soon discovered that the public was eager to read and know more about this topic. There was a general air of excitement about the changes taking place in the USSR, as people around the world felt that the old Cold War regime was beginning to crumble.



It is within this context that the world media went crazy when the official Soviet news agency, TASS (the Telegraph Agency of the Soviet Union), put out a newswire on October 9, 1989 that shocked the world. The wire discussed a story of giant aliens landing in a flying saucer right in the middle of a park in the city of Voronezh. Hardly anyone in the West had ever heard about Voronezh before this story, despite the city's location just three hundred miles southwest of Moscow.

The furor was so big that even the *New York Times*—normally not a UFO-friendly publication—ran three articles on consecutive days, making the front page story on October 10 with the title, "A TASS Bulletin: Knobby Aliens Were Here." Another American newspaper, *Newsday*, filled its entire front page with the Voronezh story under the headline, "Close Encounters of the Soviet Kind!" On October 14, the *New York Times* published an editorial titled "The Voronezh Visitors," which although written in a tongue-in-cheek style, admitted that "skepticism can be taken too far" and that "TASS has broken the story of the century."

## THE ORIGINAL TASS NEWSWIRES

The now famous October 9 TASS original newswire announced to the world that, "scientists have confirmed that an unidentified flying object recently landed in the Russian city of Voronezh. They have also identified the landing site and found traces of aliens who made a short promenade about the park." TASS added that there had been at least three incidents that included the following sight:

A large shining ball or disc was seen hovering above the park, it then landed, a hatch opened and 1, 2 or 3 creatures similar to humans and a small robot came out. The aliens were three or even four meters high (about 9 to 10 feet), but with very small heads, witnesses say.

Apparently, after taking a short stroll in the park and terrifying the local witnesses, the aliens went back to their craft and took off immediately. At first glance, the Voronezh affair looked like the ideal UFO case because TASS noted that the details and landing marks had been confirmed by Genrikh Silanov, head of the Voronezh Geophysical Laboratory. Silanov was quoted in the original TASS report stating,

We detected a circle 20 meters in diameter. Four 4-5 centimeter deep dents, each with a diameter of 14-16 centimeters were clearly visible. They are situated in the four points of a rhomb. We found two mysterious pieces of rock. At first glance they looked like a sandstone of a deep-red color. However, mineralogical analysis has shown that the substance cannot be found on Earth.

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CONFIRMED UFO LANDING IN VORONEZH; WITNESSES FRIGHTENED.  
9/10 TASS 20

VORONEZH OCTOBER 9 TASS - SCIENTISTS HAVE CONFIRMED THAT AN UNIDENTIFIED FLYING OBJECT RECENTLY LANDED IN A PARK IN THE RUSSIAN CITY OF VORONEZH.

THEY HAVE ALSO IDENTIFIED THE LANDING SITE AND FOUND TRACES OF ALIENS WHO MADE A SHORT PROMENADE ABOUT THE PARK.

ALIENS VISITED THE PLACE AFTER DARK, AT LEAST THREE TIMES, LOCALS REPORT.

A LARGE SHINING BALL OR DISC WAS SEEN HOVERING ABOVE THE PARK; IT THEN LANDED, A HATCH OPENED AND 1, 2 OR 3 CREATURES SIMILAR TO HUMANS AND A SMALL ROBOT CAME OUT.

THE ALIENS WERE THREE OR EVEN FOUR METERS HIGH, BUT WITH VERY SMALL HEADS, WITNESSES SAY.

THEY WALKED NEAR THE BALL OR DISC AND THEN DISAPPEARED INSIDE. ONLOOKERS WERE OVERWHELMED WITH A FEAR WHICH LASTED FOR SEVERAL DAYS.

WE IDENTIFIED THE LANDING SITE BY MEANS OF BIOLOCATION. GENRIKH SILANOV, HEAD OF THE VORONEZH GEOPHYSICAL LABORATORY SAID IN AN INTERVIEW.

WE DETECTED A CIRCLE 20 METERS IN DIAMETER. FOUR 4-5 CENTIMETER DEEP DENTS, EACH WITH A DIAMETER OF 14-16 CENTIMETERS WERE CLEARLY VISIBLE. THEY ARE SITUATED IN THE FOUR POINTS OF A RHOMB. WE FOUND TWO MYSTERIOUS PIECES OF ROCK.

AT FIRST GLANCE THEY LOOKED LIKE SANDSTONE OF A DEEP-RED COLOUR. HOWEVER, MINERALOGICAL ANALYSIS HAS SHOWN THAT THE SUBSTANCE CANNOT BE FOUND ON EARTH. HOWEVER, ADDITIONAL TESTS ARE NEEDED TO REACH A MORE DEFINITE CONCLUSION.

SILANOV USED BIOLOCATION TO TRACE THE EARTHLY TRAILS OF THE ALIENS.

WITNESSES WERE NOT INFORMED ABOUT THE EXPERIMENT, BUT THE ROUTE ALONG WHICH THE ALIENS WALKED AS DESCRIBED BY THE ONLOOKERS AND THE ONE ESTABLISHED SCIENTIFICALLY COINCIDED.

MANY ALSO CLAIM TO HAVE SEEN A BANANA-SHAPED OBJECT IN THE SKY AND A CHARACTERISTIC ILLUMINATED SIGN, AS DESCRIBED IN THE U.S. SAGA MAGAZINE.

IT IS UNLIKELY THAT RESIDENTS OF VORONEZH COULD HAVE READ THE MAGAZINE.

STEN ENDS \*\*\*

The October 9, 1989 TASS newswire, "Confirmed UFO Landing in Voronezh."

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LEFT: Credit: Huneus Collection/Soviet Union RIGHT: Credit: Huneus Collection/TASS

TOP AND BOTTOM: Credit: Huneus Collection/Voronezh Anomalous Phenomena Research Committee MIDDLE: Credit: Huneus Collection/Moscow News



Silanov cautioned, however, that "additional tests are needed to reach a more definitive conclusion." The TASS report added that Silanov had used a technique known as "biolocation" (something similar to dowsing). Additionally, TASS reported that witnesses had seen "a banana-shaped object in the sky and a characteristic illuminated sign, as described in the U.S. *Saga* magazine, [but it] is unlikely that residents of Voronezh could have read the magazine." Only seasoned ufologists will likely recall *Saga* and its sister publication *UFO Report*, which used to be fairly popular newsstand UFO magazines in the 1970s. The fact that, by 1989, both American magazines had been out of circulation for nearly eight years showed that TASS kept pretty impressive ufological records.

As the bizarre account of the Voronezh encounter unfolded on the second day, the story became even stranger. An Associated Press newswire from Moscow stated that the newspaper *Sovetskaya Kultura* (Soviet Culture) had reported that "a three-eyed alien with a robot sidekick landed by UFO made a boy vanish by zapping him with a pistol." Moreover, Genrikh Silanov claimed that he had been misquoted by TASS, particularly with regards to the two red rocks of alleged alien origin. "The rock they described as extraterrestrial is in fact a piece of iron oxide which could easily have originated on Earth," Silanov told the Associated Press, adding that there was indeed "a landing site" or something resembling one in Voronezh, although similar effects could have been caused by an underground pipe, cable, or reservoir.

TASS stood by its correspondent Vladimir Lebedev, who filed the original report from Voronezh. "It's not April Fool's today," a TASS duty officer told the Associated Press. Although Western reporters tried to ridicule the incident in the following days, other than Silanov's retraction of the two red rocks, the basic details of the incident were not denied by Soviet authorities, at least initially. Later, on October 28, the French Press Agency reported that a commission chaired by Igor Sarotsev, vice-rector of the University of Voronezh, issued a report which showed "there exists no verifiable proof of a landing by aliens in Voronezh." But, as discussed below, there was disagreement amongst other scientists from the Voronezh Anomalous Phenomena Research Committee.

## THE VORONEZH WITNESSES

The worldwide media level of interest in Voronezh generated a great deal of confusion because the great majority of Western reporters were unaware of the complex and often conflictive history of ufology in the old Soviet communist society. It soon became apparent that at least half a dozen

UFO cases took place in 1989 in Voronezh, all between September 21 and October 3. The most famous case was the landing on September 27 in Voronezh, in which the main witnesses were a group of children playing in the early evening.

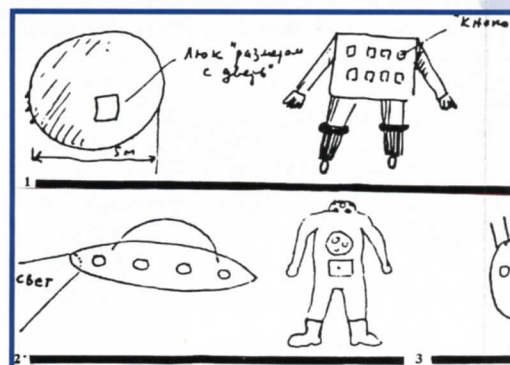
The children were interviewed by various local and national TV news programs, which were later rebroadcast in the West, and their drawings of the aliens and their craft were published by the press worldwide. As the children played in the park, a pink glow appeared in the sky, circling, then hovering, and finally landing. The boys described it as a deep red ball about 10 meters in diameter. One child in particular, Vasya Surin, would later provide a colorful description of the 9-to-10-foot-tall, three-eyed alien wearing silvery overalls, bronze-colored boots, and a disc on his chest.

Yet, not all of the witnesses were children. The *New York Times* quoted Lieutenant Sergei A. Matseyev of the Voronezh district police station, stating that "it was not an optical illusion." Matseyev didn't actually see the aliens, but he admitted that there "was certainly a body flying in the sky" at low altitude, emitting no sound, and moving at high speed. "I thought I must be really tired," he added, "but I rubbed my eyes and [the UFO] didn't go away. Then I figured, in this day and age, anything is possible."

The high point of strangeness came when the aliens used some kind



An artist's rendition of one of the landings, from the Russian book, *UFOs in Voronezh*.



Eyewitness illustrations from the children published by Moscow News.



An artist's rendition of the so-called Voronezh giants, from the Russian book, *UFOs in Voronezh*.





Artist's rendition of the main UFO landing of September 27, 1989 in Voronezh's South Park by German artist D. Menningramm.

of device or "pistol." Allegedly, the alien visitors aimed a long tube at a sixteen-year-old boy and made him disappear. The tall aliens with small heads went back into the craft, and the UFO took off at the same time that the boy reappeared. Perhaps due to the furor caused in the American and foreign media, *Vremya* the main Soviet television newscast, decided to interview Vasya Surin. "We were scared," said Surin, adding that the UFO "hovered over the tree. Then the door opened and a tall person of about three meters looked out. He didn't have a head or shoulders either. He just had a kind of a hump. There he had three eyes, two on each side and one in the middle."

The coverage in the Soviet media was uneven, with some outlets treating it seriously and others ridiculing it. The official newspaper of the Soviet Communist Party, *Pravda*, for instance, chose to have a little fun at the expense of Voronezh, publishing a parody on December 15, 1989 titled, "Extraterrestrials in Obradovsk." The parody focused on a spaceship that appeared showing the letters "U.F.O." in Cyrillic and Latin alphabets. But the weekly *Moscow News*, which had become one of Russia's most freely outspoken publications in the Gorbachev era, treated the issue seriously in the article, "Aliens Visit Voronezh," and shed considerable more light on the flap. The article reported on such details as the findings of gamma-radiation on the landing traces in Voronezh and the calculations by local UFO researchers that, "the approximate mass of the body which exerted pressure on the ground in this spot was 11 tons."

The *Moscow News* also reported on the testimony of Voronezh mayor Viktor Atlasov regarding his support of the children who were the closest witnesses and who received much attention and ridicule for their descriptions of the giant alien beings. "I believe the boys," Mayor Atlasov told the newspaper.

More details were also later provided by the children, including Zhenya Blinov, who talked about a three-meter-tall being who disembarked on the evening of September 27. Zhenya explained, "On his head, I saw two eyes and slightly above them a red lamp. On his breast there was a disc with three spots of different colors, and slightly below it there was a rectangle which started sticking out from the body." *Moscow News* also located witnesses to another UFO sighting over the city on the evening of September 29. Accountant Olga Poludneva described a luminous ball flying above the houses, a fact confirmed by her friend Lyudmila

Kupriyanova, who also saw the mysterious object with a luminous tail.

On October 28, skeptical results of the sighting were issued by a local commission chaired by Igor Sarotsev, vice-rector of the University of Voronezh. His report stated that "there exists no verifiable proof of a landing by aliens in Voronezh." Their tests for micro-organisms and spectro-chemical analysis failed to uncover "any anomaly either in the earth or surrounding vegetation." Sarotsev acknowledged, "The presence of a larger than normal quantity of the radioactive isotope cesium in the area of the alleged landing," but added that, "after Chernobyl, this kind of phenomenon has been found in many areas."

Additional data was gathered by well-known ufologist and scientist, Dr. Jacques Vallee, who flew to Moscow in January 1990 with French journalist Martine Castello. Although they didn't actually travel to Voronezh, they met with many of the local scientists who investigated the UFO wave. The results of this trip were published by Vallee in his 1992 book, *UFO Chronicles of the Soviet Union: A Cosmic Samizdat*. Of particular interest were the accounts of UFO sightings by personnel from Voronezh-Energo, the Voronezh hydroelectric power station. For example, employee Inna Nikitina reported that, "Around 9:00 P.M., for five to ten minutes, I observed a fairly large flattened sphere, shaped like an orange. This happened in the vicinity of the mining equipment plant. I experienced a feeling of intense fear for which I could not account."

More testimony came from Yuli Sviridov, chief engineer of the Transelectroproject Institute, who described "a big, bright red sphere move between the houses at an altitude of a thousand feet, with a crimson halo along the edges," on the evening of September 27. Then, in late September, fifty-six-year-old factory worker M. N. Polyakov was driving with a friend toward a southern suburb of Voronezh, when suddenly their car engine stopped. The car lights, radio, and everything else electronic in the vehicle came to a halt. Polyakov and his friend then noticed an object hovering in the sky above their car. "Suddenly a light appeared from it," he said, and "the beam came down and slowly moved along the ground toward us . . . when the beam approached the car I experienced an unpleasant fear. I felt constrained. I did not want to move or to do anything."



An artist's rendition of the case of factory worker Polyakov, whose car was stopped by a beam emitted by a UFO during the Voronezh wave.

TOP: Credit: Huneus Collection/D. Menningramm BOTTOM: Credit: Huneus Collection/Voronezh Anomalous Phenomena Research Committee

Credit: Huneus Collection/Voronezh Anomalous Phenomena Research Committee



## FINDINGS OF THE VORONEZH ANOMALOUS PHENOMENA RESEARCH COMMITTEE

Back in the mid-1980s, scientists throughout the USSR had formed local committees to investigate UFOs designated officially as anomalous phenomena. The local Voronezh committee included Alexander Mosolov, an aviation engineer; Vyacheslav Martynov, chief engineer at an aeronautical plant; Genrikh Silanov, the geophysicist quoted in the famous TASS newswire; and Dr. Yuri Lozotsev, an associate professor of mechanics and specialist in materials science with the All-Union External Railroad Transport Institute, who later corresponded extensively with many Western ufologists. This group eventually published a 1990 book about their investigation titled, *UFOs in Voronezh*. Unfortunately, this book was never translated into English, but the group's main conclusions were conveyed by Dr. Lozotsev in his correspondence with Western researchers. An April 17, 1990 letter by Dr. Lozotsev to the Hungarian-American military ufologist, Colonel Colman von Keviczky, described the primary conclusions of the investigation:

4. Spectators reported there were several humanoids and one artificial mechanical object that was described as a "TV set on legs." Some children say the humanoids had three eyes or two eyes and a red lamp between them: had no nose but one or two holes instead of it. The skin reported to be green or brown (different landings). Humanoids were dressed in 'blue raincoats' and bronze-colored heavy boots.

5. Sign "Ж" on the board of some vehicles (different sightings were also reported).

6. The major type of UFOs in the skies of Voronezh were the following: classic saucer, hat-shaped, ball-shaped, egg-shaped, etc. The colors were metallic, orange, red, blue and others.

Dr. Lozotsev added that "UFO activities over Voronezh are continuing," and that the "last report we have received was dated April 4, 1990. We go on with our exploration



The scientific team from the Voronezh Anomalous Phenomena Research Committee, authors of the book, *UFOs in Voronezh*.

1. We have found several round tracks (the diameter is 150 mm and the depth is 50 mm) in the South Park in Voronezh. We suppose there were at least 5 landings and one low hanging of UFOs over the area in the period from September 22 to October 3, 1989. The weight of one of those vehicles was approximately 11,500 kilograms (this figure was computed according to the deformation of the soil under the tracks).

2. Magnetic field characteristics had an extreme magnitude in the centers of the landings.

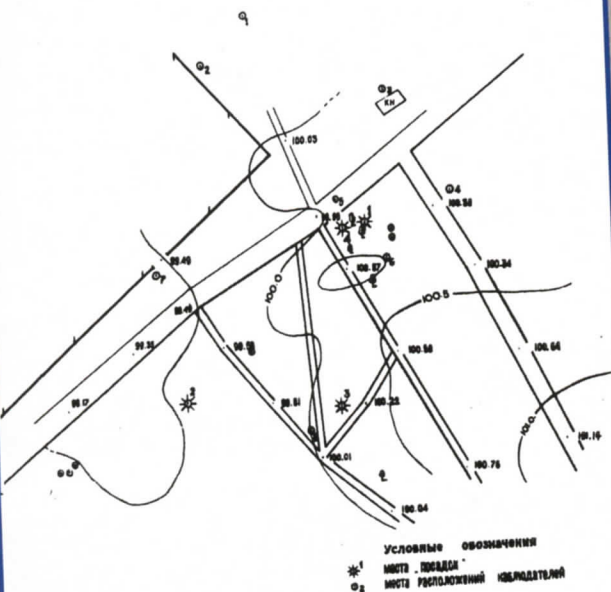
3. Micro-organisms in the soil were oppressed in the centers of the landings (the quantity was ten times less than usual).

and hope that our work will be a modest contribution . . . in the serious and complex study of the UFO problem."

A little clarification must be added to Dr. Lozotsev's fifth point regarding the symbol "Ж" seen on the UFO by some witnesses. This symbol received a great deal of attention in the press, as it seemed to be almost identical to the famous and controversial "Ummo" symbol reported in Spain in the 1960s. The Spanish incident was an extremely complex affair investigated by well-known Spanish ufologist and author Antonio Ribera, which involved a number of fairly technical letters written allegedly by inhabitants from the planet Ummo who were visiting Earth. However, before drawing any conclusions, it should be noted that this symbol is also almost identical to the letter



Участок Южного парка  
Места "посадок" и наблюдателей



Топографический план участка Южного парка.  
Места расположения наблюдателей:  
1 — Н. Крылова, Е. Сорокина, Ю. Шолохова;  
2 — А. Панин; 3 — Е. Блинов; 4 — Р. Тор-  
шин; 5 — С. Макаров, А. Никаноров; 6 —  
В. Старцев; 7 — Н. Гладкова; 8 — В. Сурин.

Map of the UFO landing site in Voronezh's South Park, from the Russian book, *UFOs in Voronezh*.

"zh" in the Russian Cyrillic alphabet, and may not be at all related to the so-called Umno affair.

It is also important to note that the Voronezh UFO wave didn't happen in a vacuum. Although the incidents were most widely reported in both the Soviet and international media, they were certainly not the only close encounters with aliens reported in the Soviet Union in 1989. They were, in fact, part of a large UFO wave registered all over the country in that fateful year. Some of the other significant ET incidents reported that year included a series of close encounters in the village of Konantsevo (Harovsk District, Vologda Region) in June. There were also several abduction or contactee cases in various parts of the USSR during the month of July 1989, including Kiev, the capital of Ukraine; Tbilisi, the capital of Georgia; and Solnechnogorsk in the Moscow Region, in which a painter was abducted by aliens (his experience was later reproduced in a series of paintings). Finally, there were a series of UFO and alien incidents in the Chernyshev District of the Perm Region, west of the Ural Mountains,

One of the very few UFO photographs taken during the Voronezh wave.

which eventually led this area to be known as the "Perm anomalous zone." This area continues to this day to be one of Russia's ufological hot spots.

The Voronezh affair receded in time as other intense UFO waves in Belgium, Mexico, and elsewhere replaced them in the international media. They are mostly forgotten by the general public by now, but the level of media intensity received at the time still marks them as one of the most highly publicized waves in ufological history. Regardless of what really transpired in this Russian city, the Voronezh affair should be considered as highly significant at least from a sociological point of view. At least for a few days, the incidents changed the world's perception of the UFO subject, giving a glimpse of what could happen if government authorities, scientists, ufologists, and the media concentrate their efforts in solving, or at least dealing officially with the topic of alien visitations to Earth.



The UFO landing site in Voronezh's South Park, from the Russian book, *UFOs in Voronezh*.

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